

Personal Statement – Professional Masters in Games Development

Game design feels a lot like motorcycle racing to me. It's a technical sport where progress is measured in analysis, iteration, and an honest confrontation with failure. On the track, you improve your lap times by watching footage, tweaking the bike's set up, knowing your limits, and learning from each mistake. Game design moves at the same pace. Prototypes break, playtests uncover bugs, and real progress happens only after you loop through research and player feedback.

I don't romanticize either world. The comparison just shows what I believe design to be: a field where mistakes happen, responsibility matters, and growth flows from examining failure instead of hiding from it. That mindset has shaped how I work and how I react to criticism.

In my culture, there's a saying: "Thất bại là mẹ thành công" – failure is the mother of success. For a long time, I treated it as a nice saying. Experience turned it into a lived principle. Even my name, Công Thành, plays against "Thành Công" (success), and that constant reminder says progress comes from effort, missteps and reflection. I now see mistakes as hints about where my knowledge or process can improve, which changes the way I deal with responsibility, iteration and teamwork.

When I was interning at LacBird early in my bachelor's, I ended up as the lead designer and project manager for a small four-person narrative game. I didn't grasp the weight of the role. Scope wasn't clear, the production wasn't structured, and I lacked the leadership chops to guide the team. The project stalled, and I stopped leading for a while.

Looking back at it, it feels like I misjudged a corner on the track. The fact that I failed was less important than the lesson I gained. It was my own lack of preparation and discipline rather than the team or the environment. I was forced to confront what I lack in planning, communication and decision making, all of which I had previously ignored.

Even after graduating with a Second Class (2:2) BSc (Hons) in Computer Games Design and Programming from Staffordshire University, I didn't let it define me. Instead, I saw them as an opportunity to sharpen my work, and me. I've been rebuilding my fundamentals and confidence through both hard work and ambition.

Today, I'm a game designer at VigaFun. My work splits between gameplay systems, level design, sound design, and with a focus on systems design. I love to come up with new mechanics, difficulty curves and observing player progression through data feedback. Even when I contribute to a minor role, I keep the whole development cycle in mind because good design decisions can't ignore production realities.

A recent project taught me a lesson about optimization and player's perspective. Players dropped the game because ads appeared too soon, even though the core gameplay was on

point. Instead of adding more content, I suggested adjusting the pacing and duration of ads with the intention of improving retention rate and IAP (In App Purchasing) in the long run. The tweak boosted retention in a subsequent update. This reminded me of the first lesson I learned from failure: design decisions carry real weight. Poor pacing, whether in game flow or monetization, shows its cost when you look at the data and player actions. Anchoring iteration in evidence, not assumption, has made me more disciplined, accountable and respectful of the player's experience.

With this perspective and my experience on large projects, I'm ready for the next step. I'm applying to Abertay University's MProf Games Development because the studio-based structure, collaborative focus and reflective practice line up perfectly with the professional environment where I want to thrive as a designer.

I grew up learning to build games in Vietnam, a setting that pushed me to juggle shifting production standards, never-same player habits, and a constant stream of new challenges. Instead of shaking my confidence, the work forced me to broaden my outlook and sharpen my flexibility. Those traits feel especially vital in a setting where ideas must survive collaboration, critique, and real-world constraints, exactly what I picture an international studio doing.

So why the MProf in Games Development? It's not a sidestep, it's my conscious decision towards studio-grade practice. I want a place where every design choice is held up, debated, and refined inside a proper studio workflow. Abertay's focus on realistic production, reflective learning, and teamwork mirrors how I already tackle projects, but it also raises the bar. I aim to bring more than my own work; I plan to give thoughtful feedback, aid iteration, and own the decisions that ripple through the team. I'm ready for more responsibility, keep sharpening my craft through date and experience, and grow into a designer who balances vision with production discipline.